A FRAMEWORK FOR RETROSPECTIVE PROGRAM EVALUATION USING FRAGMENTED EVIDENCE IN DATA-LIMITED INTERNATIONAL DEVELOPMENT CONTEXTS

Concept Paper
Presented

by

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INTRODUCTION

1.1 Context and Research Problem

Monitoring and evaluation systems are widely used in international development to assess program performance and support learning. Monitoring refers to the continuous tracking of program activities and outputs during implementation, while evaluation refers to the systematic assessment of program outcomes and impacts (Dijkzeul and Salomons, 2021; Glewwe and Todd, 2022; Samset and Volden, 2022). Project and program evaluations are generally organized into three stages: ex-ante, interim, and ex-post evaluation (Linzalone and Schiuma, 2015; Glewwe and Todd, 2022). Ex-post evaluation takes place at the closing stage of a program or after its completion and aims to generate lessons learned, evaluative judgments, and insights into results and implementation processes (Linzalone and Schiuma, 2015).

At a methodological level, ex-post evaluation already faces organization and interpretation challenges even when both qualitative and quantitative evidence are available. These challenges become more pronounced in participatory and transdisciplinary development contexts involving multiple stakeholders with different objectives and evaluative perspectives (Späth, 2008). In practice, most ex-post evaluations occur in data-limited environments: baseline data is often missing, monitoring systems are incomplete, and documentation is weak or inconsistent (Bhagwat, Pathak and Venkataramani, 2011; Dörrbecker, 2023). Despite these conditions, there is still no structured framework that systematically brings together fragmented and heterogeneous sources of qualitative and documentary evidence into a coherent approach for ex-post program evaluation in data-limited international development contexts.

1.2 Practical Motivation and Research Contribution

Following the closure of SUCO's Guatemala VCP (Volunteer Cooperation Program), the ex-post evaluation highlighted several challenges commonly identified in data-limited environments, including information availability, unplanned evaluation processes, long delays between interventions and outcomes, and resource limitations (Bhagwat, Pathak and Venkataramani, 2011). This case served to identify and better understand these methodological challenges. The Honduras program, scheduled to close in early 2027 and involving other partners and volunteers, provides the main empirical context for this study and the opportunity to develop a more structured evaluation approach. This study aims to contribute a structured framework for transforming fragmented retrospective evidence into transparent evaluative judgments in data-limited international development contexts.

PRELIMINARY LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Ex-Post Evaluation: Frameworks, Dimensions and Methodologies

The literature describes ex-post evaluation as a flexible framework rather than a single fixed method. The OECD-DAC criteria (relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, impact, sustainability) provide a common reference, but in practice they must be adapted into context-specific indicators (OECD, 2025). In different settings, this often involves adding contextual dimensions or using structured assessment tools adapted to project realities (Samset and Volden, 2022; Dörrbecker, 2023; Ponanan and Satirasetthavee, 2025). Ex-post evaluation is also multidimensional in nature, examining program results, implementation processes, contextual factors, and possible causal relationships between interventions and observed outcomes (Langbein, 2014). Evaluators therefore typically rely on mixed quantitative and qualitative methods to understand both program functioning and effects (Knook *et al.*, 2018; Schimpf, Barbrook-Johnson and Castellani, 2021).

2.2 Program Evaluation in Data-Limited Contexts

While ex-post evaluation faces important data limitations across multiple sectors (Fadiga and Katjiuongua, 2014; de Jong, Vignetti and Pancotti, 2019; Elgendy *et al.*, 2022), these limitations are further amplified in international development due to incomplete monitoring systems, loss of institutional memory linked to staff turnover (Hallam and Bonino, 2013), and reliance on diverse qualitative and documentary sources. In these cases, evaluators often work with partial and non-standardized information, reducing the robustness of evaluation findings (Castaño, Blanco and Martinez, 2019).

In addition, ex-post evaluation practices vary widely across studies in terms of methods, data sources, and outcome measures, making evidence harder to compare or combine (Knook *et al.*, 2018). Consequently, evaluators must reconstruct past performance from scattered materials such as reports, interviews, and documents, increasing workload and concerns about data reliability (Nicolaisen and Driscoll, 2014;

Dijkzeul and Salomons, 2021). Overall, there is still limited guidance on how to do this reconstruction systematically under such constraints.

2.3 Retrospective Program Reconstruction and Multidimensional Rating Systems

Evaluation frameworks and structured tools such as scoring matrices are widely used to support multidimensional evaluative judgment (Samset and Volden, 2022; OECD, 2025). In data-limited contexts, some retrospective evaluations use flexible and case-specific approaches to reconstruct program performance from fragmented qualitative evidence (Dershem, Komakhidze and Berianidze, 2023). The literature nevertheless shows that several relevant methodological components already exist. Some studies combine retrospective reconstruction with structured assessment approaches at smaller scales (Dershem, Komakhidze and Berianidze, 2023), while others develop tools for translating qualitative evidence into scoring systems (Garbarino and Holland, 2009). More comprehensive evaluation systems have also been proposed (Lauras, Marquès and Gourc, 2010; Welde and Volden, 2018), but the integration of these approaches for data-limited program evaluation in international development contexts remains limited.

PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design and Questions

The study adopts a pragmatic and applied design aimed at developing a structured framework for ex-post program evaluation in data-limited international development contexts. It integrates existing evaluative and methodological components into a coherent approach, using SUCO program closure in Honduras as a contextual case. The study is guided by the following research question: how can fragmented qualitative and documentary evidence be translated into evaluative judgments through a structured framework for retrospective program evaluation in data-limited international development contexts? To address this question, the research examines how methodological components related to retrospective performance reconstruction and evaluative judgment can be combined to support consistent and transparent evaluation processes in data-limited settings. It also explores how structured use of fragmented qualitative and documentary evidence can improve evaluative coherence and applicability in international development program closure contexts.

3.2 Methodological Approach

The framework is developed through a multi-stage process combining program reconstruction, evaluative design, and use of evidence in data-limited contexts. First, the program is reconstructed by organizing fragmented information into a hierarchy linking the program, projects, and deliverables. This reconstruction is guided by categories derived from the evaluation literature (Youker, 2003; Levin and Ward, 2016; Palomares, 2019) and draws on program documentation, project tools, and input from key informants, including the country representative and volunteers, ensuring traceability between outputs and evaluation units.

Second, an evaluative structure is developed using the OECD-DAC criteria (OECD, 2025), translated into an anchored ordinal scoring system with defined dimensions and descriptive anchors (Agresti, 2010; Martinez-Martin, 2010; Casper *et al.*, 2020). Based on this structure, tailored data collection tools align evaluative dimensions with relevant respondent categories, distinguishing internal program functions from external partner contributions. These tools are used in structured group sessions with partner organizations to collectively complete and validate project-level scoring. This process is complemented by a systematic review of project documentation to support score attribution and consistency.

Once information is reconstructed and evaluated, data are organized into a structured relational database covering volunteers, mandates, projects, program components, partners, and deliverables, ensuring consistency and traceability while serving as an organizational layer rather than an analytical model. Finally, analysis relies on the structured scoring system as the primary evaluative tool, supporting coherent and reproducible evaluative judgments across reconstructed program data (Agresti, 2010; Schnuerch *et al.*, 2022; Lepskiy, 2023; Brauer and Day, 2025). The outcome is a coherent and reproducible framework for retrospective evaluation in data-limited contexts.

3.3 Conclusion

This study proposes a structured framework for retrospective program evaluation in data-limited international development contexts. It combines program reconstruction, evaluative dimensions, and systematic use of fragmented qualitative and documentary evidence to support consistent evaluative judgments. Overall, the framework aims to improve clarity, transparency, and comparability in retrospective evaluations and can be applied to similar program closure contexts in international development. A preliminary high-level timeline of the proposed research is provided in Appendix A.

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APPENDIX A – HIGH-LEVEL TIMELINE PROPOSAL

Research Phases	2026 Q2	2026 Q3	2026 Q4	2027 Q1	2027 Q2	2027 Q3	2027 Q4	2028 Q1
SUCO Approval and Concept Paper Approval	■							
Doctoral Agreement and Data Access Authorization	■							
Research Methodology II and Literature Review Submission	■	■						
Program Reconstruction Framework Development	■	■						
Development of Evaluation Dimensions and Scoring System	■	■						
Validation of the Program Reconstruction Framework and Ordinal Rating System		■						
Development of Interview and Data Collection Instruments			■					
Dataset Structure and Analytical Strategy Development			■					
Research Proposal Course and Proposal Submission			■					
Program Reconstruction with Country Representative				■				
Group Sessions with Partners and Volunteers				■	■			
Individual Validation and Follow-Up Sessions				■	■			
Finalization of Data Collection Activities (Before Program Closure)					■			
Data Management, Processing and Analysis					■	■		
Dissertation Writing		■	■	■	■	■	■	
Revision, Final Submission and Presentation Preparation						■	■	■